

Looking Back

My favourite love story was about Orpheus & Eurydice. I wrote this when I had just moved to Bangalore after living 18 years of my childhood in Chennai.

When I was a kid, I always wondered
If Orpheus loved Eurydice so deeply that it made the whole world cry
Why did he look back?
Wasn't his love enough to sustain all uncertainty he felt ?
I always thought that Orpheus was a foolish man
Maybe he didn't love her enough.
How hard could it have been not to look back ?

18 is a very confusing age
You just can't seem to figure out how you're going wrong every single time.
The levels of transition you go through,
The number of difficult choices you have to make
You're just stumbling through life on a rocky path to nowhere.

I miss my old self. Where did that go?
The carefree attitude of a boy who didn't have anything to worry about.
I cannot recognize myself in old photos,
He seems so happy. Yet he is frozen.
My memories haunt me at night.
When did this change happen?

It is raining here at Bangalore.
An air of melancholy and sadness.
The memories are distinct in my head but I cant seem to touch them.
A forbidden fruit. Maybe this is why Adam couldn't resist himself.

I keep looking back. Hoping, praying that I go back to past and everything becomes normal.
But maybe, since I'm looking back, my childhood slips further away from me

Maybe I'm doomed to look forward with that uncertain feeling in my heart that maybe,

Just maybe my childhood self will meet me.

But it's hard. I cannot help but look back.

I think I now understand Orpheus' Dilemma.

I think I understand his pain.

Opportunity loss of setting for less

This prose was written as response to my experience while undertaking a college assignment.

The biggest loss to humanity isn't when people do not get the opportunities they deserve. Rather, the biggest loss to humanity or India to be specific is when the people settle for less.

We always hear two extreme and opposite sides of a story. The top 10% richest persons control 90% of the wealth and that the poorest of people never get their economic justice. But not much is known about the middle layer, or as we conventionally call them "the middle class Indian citizens". What are their aspirations and dreams? What do they really desire from life? Do they aspire for greater things? Do they have tragedies that prevent them from achieving it? What is the middle class Indian's dream?

As part of our College Assignment, we were asked to interview marginalised people in our society and find out their life story. This exercise was conducted in order to understand and find out how it feels to be in someone else's shoes; to look at life through their lens. An exercise in empathy, it would show us that there are unwritten struggles that people go through in life and that the common man's struggles must be celebrated or atleast remembered in history. History is written by the Victors, so it is left upto us to write about the ones who lost.

Lekha (my friend) and I took up the task dauntingly. We walked the streets of SG Palya to find out the people who tend to be invisible and find out their story. We found a construction site and asked the construction worker politely if he would tell us his story. We were greeted with stares from other construction workers- it is not everyday that you would find two enthusiastic college students interviewing you about your life story. After a lot of coaxing, the man named Ahmed (name changed for privacy purposes) told us his story. And his story was ... uneventful.

Now don't get me wrong, we weren't looking for deeply disturbing tragedies in his life. Well, maybe we did. Maybe we expected a blockbuster movie type story where he went through different obstacles and how he came out of it. Maybe we expected a fantasy story, a fairy tale ending. We expected that it would have a moving ending, a perfect inspirational story to our CIA perhaps. But we couldn't be more wrong.

He had a fairly common life like any other Indian would. He didn't receive education because he didn't want to, not because he couldn't receive it. When he was of working age, he came to Bangalore to work at construction sites. Slowly but steadily, he had a bunch of men working under him and he was earning well enough to feed his family. And he will be passing on his skills to his sons when they grow up. Asked whether he had any regrets doing this particular job or whether the opportunities education could've provided him, he simply shrugged and said, "Not really."

We were walking back home and that's when I realized something about Bangalore. Thousands of people come here to fulfill their dreams and make something out of their lives. They wish to make a name for themselves. But there are also so many other thousands of people who come here to earn their basic needs. They don't desire anything more in their lives. They don't wonder what their lives could turn out to be, what potential opportunities life may offer to them. The well-to-do people stay in the posh apartments that the middle class Indian people construct. Without these common people, our society wouldn't function. They are absolutely important in our survival as human beings. And despite the humongous role they play in our lives, unfortunately, they do not realize that themselves.

If only they knew what this world could offer them, what opportunities the future holds for them, what good education can do for them, they would be much better off in their lives. But they do not know and its not because they are deprived of that opportunity but because it's their personal choice to not know. Don't get me wrong. Their lives are perfectly fine the way it is and they are content in their own lives. But the opportunity cost of what their lives could be is huge. That is the problem that India faces today. The biggest loss to India isn't that people are deprived of opportunities. Rather, the biggest loss to India is that the common man doesn't aspire to great heights. And this loss is the death of what a middle class Indian man could have been.

Walls

Wrote this poem for an open mic. Got this idea when I saw a temple being constructed and I wondered whether God exists only when the temple is fully constructed? Where was God before the walls were made?

My mom says the soul of the man lives in the walls

What happens when those walls are broken down?

Was God Almighty present before the church was made?

Or was he born into existence post construction?

What happens before and after?

I've moved cities, towns and villages.

I've gone through the entire spectrum of human emotions.

I've seen it all.

But when I die in the hospital bed, would my soul live in its wall?

I came back to my hometown yesterday.

The land where my dad was born.

All I saw was ruins.

In place of my house, a mosque was built.

I wondered whose soul lived in the walls

Does religion come from a place of abundance?

Do my mother's words hold true?

That in order for God to exist,

My father's soul has to be erased from existence

From the walls that were destroyed

For the mosque to be built?